

Aquifer Open Study Notes

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Nahum 1:1

message . . . vision: This opening, similar to that of other prophetic books (cp. [Obad 1:1](#); [Hab 1:1](#); [Mal 1:1](#)), identifies Nahum as a prophet, one who uttered messages from God. • Nineveh became the capital of the Assyrian Empire sometime shortly after 705 BC and remained so until its destruction in 612 BC. • The name Nahum means “comfort” or “encouragement.” An important theme of his prophecy is that God will bring encouragement to his people through Nineveh’s downfall ([Nah 1:12–15](#); see [Isa 40:1](#)).

Nahum 1:2

jealous (or *zealous*): God zealously guards the welfare of his people and zealously desires their faithfulness (see [Exod 20:4–5](#); [Deut 4:23–24](#); [6:4](#); [Jer 2:1–3:5](#)). • God’s vengeance and rage cannot be confused with the human attitude of “getting even.” God’s actions emerge from his holiness ([Jer 50:28–29](#)), justice ([Isa 63:1–9](#)), and faithfulness to the covenant with his people ([Lev 26:23–25](#); [Isa 1:24–26](#)). His vengeance is never arbitrary.

Nahum 1:2–6

The hymn’s first stanza draws from biblical texts commemorating Israel’s exodus from Egypt. The message is that everything in all creation is subject to God’s sovereign power, and God will ensure the punishment of those who oppose him.

Nahum 1:2–11

This short, two-stanza hymn ([1:2–6](#), [7–11](#)) tells of God’s sovereign power.

Nahum 1:3

slow to get angry: God’s patience with disobedience is linked to his faithful love ([Exod 34:6](#); [Num 14:18](#); [Ps 103:8](#); [Joel 2:13](#)). This trait had disappointed Jonah, who wanted Nineveh

destroyed immediately ([Jon 4:2](#)). Because God is patient, he sometimes delays the deserved punishment of sinners ([Neh 9:29–30](#); [Rom 2:4](#); [2 Pet 3:9](#)), but those guilty of persisting in sin will ultimately face God’s judgment ([Exod 34:7](#); [Rom 14:10](#); [2 Cor 5:10](#); [Rev 14:6–7](#)). • the whirlwind and the storm: This imagery describes the fury of God’s judgment against the wicked (see also [Isa 29:6](#)).

Nahum 1:4

Like clouds ([1:3](#)) and mountains ([1:5](#)), oceans and rivers are under God’s sovereign control. The Old Testament prophets often recall God’s actions against the seas and rivers during the Exodus ([Exod 15:8–10](#); [2 Sam 22:16](#); [Pss 66:6](#); [77:16](#); [Hab 3:15](#)). God’s power over the waters repudiated the mythology of the ancient Canaanites, who believed that the oceans and the rivers were under the control of the sea-god, Yam. • Bashan, situated east of the Sea of Galilee, was known for its rich pastureland, ideal for raising cattle (cp. [Mic 7:14](#)). • Carmel, on the Mediterranean coast in central Canaan, was noted for its beauty and fruitfulness ([Song 7:5](#); [Jer 50:19](#)). • Lebanon was famed for its great cedars ([1 Kgs 5:6–18](#)). Nahum lists these areas to demonstrate that even the most fertile and productive places on earth cannot withstand the power of God’s judgment.

Nahum 1:5

Old Testament poetry often mentions the shaking of the earth to commemorate the Exodus period (e.g., [Ps 18:7](#); [Hab 3:6](#); see [Exod 19:18](#)).

Nahum 1:6

The Hebrew word translated rage is repeated from [1:2](#). Its repetition brackets [1:2–6](#) as a single poetic unit.

Nahum 1:7

The Lord is good: God acts equitably when he judges the wicked. He also provides refuge for

those who trust in him. He accepts them and protects them in the midst of life's trials ([Pss 18:2; 62:5-7](#)). God's rich goodness can lead individuals to repentance ([Rom 2:2-4](#)).

Nahum 1:7-11

This second stanza (see study note on 1:2-11) concentrates on God's sovereignty, righteousness, and justice in dealing with all people.

Nahum 1:8

overwhelming flood: A metaphor for the powerful nature of God's judgment (see [2:6](#)).

Nahum 1:9

Why are you scheming: No scheme or human plot against God can succeed. Human plans are worthless if they do not match God's plans ([Ps 2; Isa 14:26-27; 23:9](#)).

Nahum 1:11

The wicked counselor is the Assyrian king. God had also dealt with the arrogant conceit of an Assyrian king in Hezekiah's time (about 701 BC; see [2 Kgs 19:35-36](#)). Assyria's *wicked counselor* contrasts with the coming Messiah, the King who is a "Wonderful Counselor" ([Isa 9:6](#)).

Nahum 1:12

The Assyrians' allies were vassal or subordinate kingdoms, including once-powerful Egypt. Ironically, a coalition of former allies gradually brought down the great Neo-Assyrian Empire between 625 and 605 BC. • O my people refers to Judah, whom God had punished earlier when the Assyrian king Sennacherib (704-681 BC) launched a campaign (701 BC) against the western states of the Near East. While Sennacherib failed to take Jerusalem ([2 Kgs 19:32-36](#)), he boasted in his annals of carrying away Jerusalem's tribute and an enormous amount of spoils from forty-six cities in Judah. Although Judah was now reduced to vassalage and faced the constant possibility of Assyrian aggression, Assyria did not defeat the

southern kingdom. Babylon did so, however, in 586 BC. Sadly, neither Israel nor Judah heeded God's repeated warnings that failure to repent would result in judgment ([Hos 11:5; Joel 2:1-27](#)).

Nahum 1:14

no more children: Nineveh would be completely annihilated. Cutting off a person's name and leaving him without a descendant meant utterly destroying him ([1 Sam 24:21; Job 18:17; Isa 14:22](#)). • None of Assyria's venerated gods could deliver Nineveh from God's death sentence. • God was already preparing a grave for Nineveh and directing Assyria's enemies to destroy the city. Assyria's proud cities fell one by one to the combined attacks of the Chaldeans, the Medes, and the Ummanmanda. Nineveh itself fell in 612 BC.

Nahum 1:15

Nahum supplements his prophecy of Judah's release from bondage ([1:13](#)) with a prediction of the arrival of a messenger bringing the good news of restored peace (see also [Isa 52:7](#)). The message of peace was that Assyria's hold on Judah would be broken and God's people would be free of its burden. This took place during the reign of Josiah (640-609 BC), after the death of the Assyrian king Ashurbanipal in 626 BC. This political message is a foretaste of God's final triumph over evil, when his people will be released from bondage to sin through the saving work of the Messiah and be given eternal peace ([Zeph 3:13; Luke 2:10-14; Acts 10:34-43; Rom 10:15; Eph 2:14-18](#)).

Nahum 2:1

Although Nineveh's defenders might fully prepare to protect the city with ramparts . . . roads . . . defenses, and forces, their efforts were doomed to failure ([1:1-14](#)).

Nahum 2:2

The vine symbolizes God's blessing his people ([Isa 27:2-6](#)), while the stripped vine reflects God's previous chastisement of them ([Isa 5:1-7](#)). The children of Israel were in a sad state compared to

the days of the great kings David and Solomon, but God promised to restore the splendor of his people.

Nahum 2:4

Chariots were virtually unstoppable in battle because of their maneuverability and power.

Nahum 2:5

The Assyrian king overcomes the initial shock of Nineveh's being attacked and shouts to his officers. He and the city have been caught off guard and they rush to the walls to thwart the siege. • to set up their defenses (literally *the covering is prepared*): The meaning of the Hebrew term here is uncertain. *Covering* probably refers to something the attackers or the defenders used to protect themselves from armaments hurled through the air.

Nahum 2:6

The rush to defend (2:5) comes too late; the defenses are already breached. • Nineveh was served by a reservoir formed by a double dam on the Khosr River, a tributary of the Tigris that flowed through the city. The reservoir was augmented by a series of flood gates. The Greek historian Diodorus reported that during this time torrential rains had already swelled the city's river system. By first closing, then opening the flood gates, Nineveh's attackers released the pent-up water as a battering ram against the city walls.

Nahum 2:7

Because Nineveh's exile had been decreed by God, it would certainly happen. • To beat their breasts was a common sign of mourning (see, e.g., [Luke 18:13](#)).

Nahum 2:8

The people would run away as fast as water flows from a breached reservoir (see study note on 2:6).

Nahum 2:9

The vast, uncounted wealth of other nations poured into the Assyrian capital as trade, tribute, and spoils, but it was gone in an instant. Ruthless aggression and wickedness may succeed temporarily, but ultimately they will be destroyed ([Prov 13:22](#); [Obad 1:15](#); [Luke 12:16–20](#)).

Nahum 2:10

plundered, empty, and ruined: The Hebrew here is alliterated for effect: buqah umbuqah umbullaqah. The effect might be translated into English as “devastated, despoiled, and destroyed.”

Nahum 2:11–13

Following the description of Nineveh's fall ([2:1–10](#)), Nahum inserts the first of three taunt songs (see also [3:8–13](#), [14–19](#); this was a common form in the ancient Near East). In biting satire, he compares Nineveh to a lion's den. King Sennacherib and other Assyrian kings had compared themselves to lions, even decorating their palaces with artistic representations of lions and of themselves on lion hunts. However, with God as its enemy, Nineveh would no longer be the lair of an invincible predator.

Nahum 2:13

Examples of the voices of Assyria's proud messengers are found in [2 Kgs 18:19–19:13](#).

Nahum 3:1

city of murder: The Assyrians' graphic cruelty is well documented. Their practices included cutting off external body parts—such as noses, ears, hands, and feet—and execution by impalement on stakes. They heaped up severed heads before the gates of besieged cities. The eyes of victims might also be put out and their skin stripped from their bodies while they were still alive.

Nahum 3:2-3

These short, staccato phrases dramatize the effects of seeing and hearing the battle. • Assyrian chariots and charioteers were feared far and wide.

Nahum 3:4

mistress of deadly charms: The Assyrians charmed other nations with wealth and promises of safety and prosperity but then victimized them through military might and economic exploitation. Therefore, their punishment was a just recompense for their deeds (see [Prov 24:12](#); [Joel 3:4-8](#); [Rev 18:6](#); [20:12](#)).

Nahum 3:5

Twice God tells Nineveh, I am your enemy (also [2:13](#)). Nineveh's judgment stands as a historical reminder that the Lord abhors sin and will deal with people and nations according to their deeds ([Pss 9:7-8](#); [62:12](#); [Jer 46:28](#); [Acts 17:31](#)). One day, God's justice will fall worldwide on those who have rebelled against him ([Rev 17-19](#)).

Nahum 3:8

Thebes, the historic capital of Egypt, was situated on both sides of the Nile in Upper Egypt. It achieved its greatest fame as the political, religious, and cultural center of Egypt's great New Kingdom (1550-1069 BC). Though no longer Egypt's capital in the 600s BC, the city was still a thriving metropolis.

Nahum 3:9-10

Thebes fell to the Assyrians under King Ashurbanipal in 663 BC. Before Ashurbanipal's victory, Thebes had seemed to have unconquerable defenses, as well as the help of all Egypt and its allies: Ethiopia, Put (perhaps the fabled land of Punt, located near what is now coastal Somalia), and Libya. None of these, however, had effectively protected Thebes. • babies were dashed to death: Ancient conquerors had the heinous practice of exterminating the infants of their enemies in this way ([2 Kgs 8:12](#); [Ps 137:9](#); [Isa 13:16, 18](#)). • Soldiers threw dice for the spoils of war, while the leaders

of the conquered people were bound in chains (see [2 Kgs 25:7](#); [Jer 40:1, 4](#); [Joel 3:3](#); [Obad 1:11](#)).

Nahum 3:12

ripe figs: Cp. [Amos 8:1-2](#); [Rev 6:13](#).

Nahum 3:14

Get ready . . . Strengthen: Nahum used sarcasm to stress that no amount of preparation would make the Assyrians able to withstand God's wrath (note also the sarcastic tone of [2:11-13](#)).

Nahum 3:15

The Old Testament often uses locusts as a metaphor for armies (see [Joel 2:1-11](#)).

Nahum 3:16

Assyrian merchants had spread throughout the Near East like locusts, filling Nineveh with untold wealth. But just as locusts desire only to satisfy their insatiable appetites and then fly off, the merchants would take their goods and go in the time of Nineveh's distress, leaving a needy populace behind.

Nahum 3:18

shepherds: With the leaders gone, Nineveh's people would be scattered like sheep. • lie dead (literally *sleep*; see [John 11:11-14](#)): Assyria's leaders, asleep during Nineveh's crisis, would sleep in death. By contrast, Israel's Shepherd does not slumber ([Ps 121:3](#)), and he will gather Israel's lost sheep ([Jer 23:3](#); [Ezek 36:35](#)).

Nahum 3:19

Nineveh deserved destruction rather than healing. Although God had been patient with Nineveh in Jonah's day ([Jon 3:10](#)), the Assyrians had returned to cruelty and would reap the harvest of their own evil (see [Prov 11:16-19](#); [Isa 66:5-6](#); [Hos 8:7](#)).

Those who had suffered under Assyria's cruelty
would welcome this message with joy.